

Week 8 — Diagnosis by Palpation

EAM310 · EAST ASIAN MEDICINE DIAGNOSIS I · VUIM SUMMER 2026

⚠ Quiz 6 — September 4, 2026

Class: Friday September 4, 2026 · 9AM–1PM

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REQUIRED READINGS — DUE BEFORE SEPTEMBER 4

FCM CHAPTER 25 — MACIOCIA

- Diagnosis by Palpation — full chapter
- Palpating skin: temperature, moisture, texture
- Palpating limbs: hands, feet, dorsum vs palm
- Palpating chest: apical beat, xiphoid area, breast
- Palpating abdomen and diagnostic points

CAM CHAPTER 9 — CHENG XINNONG

- Palpation (切診) as fourth of Four Methods
- Pulse-taking method review — consolidation
- Abdominal and channel palpation basics
- Back-Shu, Front-Mu, Lower-Sea, Ah Shi points
- Integration of all Four Pillars for final diagnosis

WEEK 8 LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- Interpret skin temperature findings (cold/hot patterns)
- Interpret skin moisture and texture findings
- Palpate the apical beat (Xu Li) and interpret findings
- Interpret abdominal palpation — masses, tenderness, texture
- Differentiate Full-Heat vs Empty-Heat by dorsum/palm comparison
- Apply cold-hands-and-feet differential (6 organ patterns)
- Interpret chest and xiphoid-area palpation findings
- Identify diagnostic point categories (Back-Shu, Front-Mu, Ah Shi)

ASSESSMENT CALENDAR

Date	Event	Material Covered
Aug 28	Week 7 Class	Diagnosis by Inquiry — 16 Questions
Sep 4	⚠ Quiz 6	Diagnosis by Palpation — skin, limbs, chest, abdomen, points
Sep 11	FINAL + Journal 26–50	Weeks 6–9 comprehensive

IN-CLASS PRACTICE — WHAT TO EXPECT

FULL-BODY PALPATION LAB

Week 8 includes hands-on partner palpation practice. Come ready to:

- Compare dorsum vs palm temperature on a partner's hand (Full-Heat vs Empty-Heat)
- Palpate the apical beat (Xu Li) and describe strength/quality
- Practice abdominal palpation — distinguish moving vs fixed masses
- Locate and palpate at least 2 Back-Shu and 2 Front-Mu points, noting tenderness

SKIN TEMPERATURE — COLD PATTERNS

General cold feeling	Cold pattern
Four limbs cold	Spleen- and/or Stomach-Yang deficiency
Loins, lower back, or feet cold	Kidney-Yang deficiency
Lower abdomen cold	Spleen-Yang deficiency

SKIN TEMPERATURE — HEAT PATTERNS (PRESSURE-DEPENDENT DIAGNOSIS)

Skin actually feels hot to touch	Damp-Heat
Hot on FIRST touch, fades with sustained pressure	Exterior Wind-Heat — pathogen still on Exterior
Hot on MEDIUM pressure, NOT on heavy pressure	Interior Heat in Middle Burner or Heart
Hot on HEAVY pressure, nearly to the bone	Empty-Heat from Yin deficiency

Key diagnostic principle: The DEPTH at which heat is felt tells you the depth of the pathology. Superficial heat that fades = exterior. Heat that only appears deep = the deepest Yin-deficiency Empty-Heat.

SKIN MOISTURE & TEXTURE

Moist skin	Invasion of exterior Wind (Cold or, more usually, Heat)
Moist, NO exterior symptoms	Spontaneous sweating from Lung-Qi deficiency
Dry skin	Blood deficiency or Lung-Yin deficiency
Rough skin	Painful Obstruction Syndrome from Wind
Scaly and dry skin	Exhaustion of Body Fluids, or severe Liver-Blood deficiency/dryness
Swollen, PITTING on pressure	"Water swelling" — Spleen- and/or Kidney-Yang deficiency
Swollen, NOT pitting (no pit left)	"Qi swelling" — Dampness or Qi stagnation

COLD HANDS & FEET — FULL DIFFERENTIAL

Pattern	Distinguishing Feature
COMMON CAUSES	
Cold hands AND feet	Spleen- or Stomach-Yang deficiency
Cold hands ONLY	Lung- and/or Heart-Yang deficiency
Cold feet ONLY	Kidney-Yang deficiency
Cold hands and feet in WOMEN	Blood deficiency
Cold hands in women specifically	Heart-Blood deficiency
Cold feet in women specifically	Liver-Blood deficiency
Cold FINGERS AND TOES specifically	Liver-Qi stagnation (Qi can't reach extremities)
LESS COMMON CAUSES	
Cold hands/feet + contradictory hot symptoms	Phlegm or interior Heat obstructing Qi circulation
Cold hands + intense Heat signs elsewhere	Heat in Pericardium at Nutritive Qi level (Four Levels) — Heat trapped, obstructing circulation to extremities

DORSUM VS PALM — FULL-HEAT VS EMPTY-HEAT

Hot DORSUM (back) of hand	Full-Heat
Hot PALM of hand	Empty-Heat

The 發熱 fā rè distinction: Classical "fever" in exterior Wind invasion actually refers to the objective hot feeling of the dorsum of hands/forehead on palpation — NOT necessarily a measured fever. Spiritual Axis Ch.74: hot palm = Heat in Intestines; cold palm = Cold in Intestines.

PALPATION OF HANDS & FEET — TEMPERATURE DIAGNOSIS	
Lung- and/or Heart-Yang deficiency	Coldness of hands ONLY
Spleen- and/or Kidney-Yang deficiency	Coldness particularly of feet, but often hands too — WHOLE LIMBS cold
Stomach-Yang deficiency	Coldness of both hands and feet
Heart-Blood deficiency (women)	Cold hands
Liver-Blood deficiency (women)	Cold feet
Liver-Qi stagnation	Cold hands/feet, particularly fingers and toes — NOT a Yang deficiency, it's stagnant Qi unable to reach extremities

Less common causes: Phlegm in the Interior obstructing Qi circulation to limbs (may also occur with Phlegm-Heat, producing contradictory hot/cold symptoms) · Very pronounced interior Heat obstructing Qi circulation so it cannot warm hands/feet — produces contradictory hot/cold symptoms (e.g., Heat in Pericardium at Nutritive Qi level: Dark-Red tongue no coating, night fever, mental restlessness — *but cold hands*).

PALPATING THE HAND — ORGAN CORRESPONDENCE MAP

The palm reflects internal organs in a pattern similar to the ear — visualize a small baby superimposed on the palm. Diagnosis: gently press the relevant area. **Sharp pain** = Full condition. **Dull soreness** = Empty condition of that organ.

Hand Zone	Corresponds To
Chest cavity organs	Lungs, Heart, Bronchi
Upper abdominal cavity	Liver, Spleen, Stomach, Pancreas
Lower abdominal cavity	Small intestine, Colon, Appendix
Reproductive/urinary organs	Kidney, Bladder, Uterus, Prostate, Cervix, Penis, Vagina
Respiratory organs	Lungs, Bronchi
Intestines/rectum area	Colon, Rectum

APICAL BEAT — "INTERIOR EMPTINESS" (XU LI 虚里)

Palpate over the left ventricle apex. Traditionally considered the end of the Stomach Great Connective Channel and reflective of the Gathering Qi (Zong Qi) of the chest.

Finding	Meaning
Clear, not hard, relatively slow	Normal
Feeble, without strength	Deficiency of Gathering Qi (Zong Qi)
Strong and hard	Excess condition of Lungs and/or Heart
Large but empty	Heart-Qi deficiency
Stopping and starting	Severe shock or alcoholism
Discrepancy between apical and radial pulse	Poor prognosis
Rapid	Shock, fright, or outburst of anger
Pulsation cannot be felt at all	Phlegm or hiatus hernia

AREA BELOW THE XIPHOID PROCESS

Should feel relatively SOFTER than the rest of the abdomen — this reflects Upper Burner Qi (Lung, Heart, Gathering Qi). Compare directly to surrounding abdomen.

Relatively soft (as expected)	Normal — smooth flow of Lung/Heart-Qi
Hard on palpation	Full condition, Qi stagnation from emotional problems — constriction of Corporeal Soul
Too soft on palpation	Heart deficiency

PALPATING THE CHEST — CENTER VS SURROUNDING

Very tender, light palpation, center (Ren-17 Shanzhong)	Heart-Blood stasis
Tender around the center	Excess condition of Lungs — often Phlegm retention
Palpation RELIEVES discomfort	Deficiency condition of Heart or Lungs
Light palpation relieves, deep pressure elicits discomfort	Combined Deficiency and Excess

PALPATING THE BREAST (LUMPS)

Critical caveat: Chinese medicine breast palpation is NEVER a substitute for Western diagnosis. Never rely on TCM palpation to distinguish benign from malignant — its purpose is identifying the CM pattern only.

Quality	Indicates
Relatively soft	Phlegm
Relatively hard	Blood stasis
Distinct edges	Phlegm
Indistinct edges	Toxic Heat
Mobile on palpation	Phlegm
Immovable on palpation	Blood stasis or Toxic Heat

Clinical Picture	Likely Diagnosis (CM pattern)
Small, movable, distinct edges, size varies w/ cycle	Fibrocystic disease — Phlegm + Qi stagnation
Single, hard, movable, distinct edges, mild pain	Fibroadenoma — Phlegm + Blood stasis
Single, hard, IMMOVABLE, indistinct margins, painless	⚠ Possible carcinoma — Phlegm + Qi stag + Blood stasis, Penetrating/Directing Vessel disharmony

ABDOMINAL PALPATION — QUICK REFERENCE	
Finding	Indicates
Solid, resilient, elastic	Good Original Qi — NORMAL
Hard / painful on palpation	Full condition
Too soft / ache relieved by palpation	Empty condition
Masses that MOVE under fingers	Qi stagnation
Masses FIXED and hard	Blood stasis

Core palpation principle (applies everywhere on the body): Moving mass = Qi. Fixed mass = Blood. This single rule underlies chest, abdomen, and channel-point palpation alike.

DIAGNOSTIC POINT CATEGORIES 診斷穴	
Point Category	Function
Back-Shu (Transporting) Points	Where Qi/Blood of a specific organ "infuses" on the back — directly related to their organ, react when organ diseased. E.g. BL-21 Weishu → Stomach; BL-13 Feishu → Lungs
Front-Mu (Collecting) Points	Particularly reactive to pathological internal-organ changes — same Full/Empty principle as Back-Shu
Lower-Sea Points	Used for diagnosis of the Fu (Yang) organs specifically
Ah Shi Points	"Oh yes!" points — tender spots with no fixed location, found by palpation alone
Sharp pain (spontaneous or on pressure)	Full condition of the relevant organ
Dull soreness (spontaneous or on pressure)	Empty condition of the relevant organ

Extra diagnostic back points beyond the standard Back-Shu set: BL-43 Gaohuangshu reflects Lung state · BL-53 Zhishi often sore in Kidney disease · BL-31/32/33/34 (Shangliao/Ciliao/Zhongliao/Xialiao) reflect reproductive system state, particularly in women.

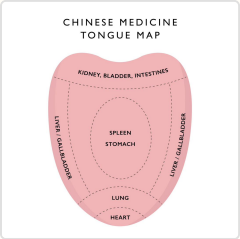
PATTERN NAME	DISEASE CATEGORY	WEEK / QUIZ

ETIOLOGY	ORGAN SYSTEM	DATE

CLINICAL ESSENTIALS — CASE NOTES

PALPATION 切診 · SKIN/CHEST/ABDOMEN	PULSE 脈診 · CUN · GUAN · CHI
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CHINESE MEDICINE TONGUE MAP



TEMP / TEXTURE / MASSES / POINTS

QUALITY / OVERALL

TREATMENT PRINCIPLE 治則

KEY POINTS / HERBS

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